diplomat—the station head of Canadian Intelligence, Olivier Sylvester. And while all this polite warfare was unfolding, a more ominous note was struck on the sidelines. Gurpatwant Singh Pannu—Nijjar's close aide and chief of another pro-Khalistan outfit, Sikhs for Justice (SFJ)—released a video threatening "Indo-Canadian Hindus". They had chosen their side, he thundered, and so they must "go to India", the words eerily echoing a common imprecation flung at dissenters back home. Pannu is wanted in India in several terror incidents. Sources say the ministry of external affairs (MEA) had confronted MacKay with such videos emerging out of Canada.

Just over a week ago, on September 10, the US-based SFJ, which supports the secession of Punjab from India and is more active in Canada, had organised a "referendum" in Surrey. The pro-Khalistan sloganeering that followed doesn't surprise locals anymore. A fourth of the town's population is Punjabi diaspora, the bulk of them '80s-'90s immigrants. The Guru Nanak Sikh Gurdwara, where the so-called referendum took place, has, in fact, become the hub of KTF, a banned terror outfit in India.



CAUSE OF CONCERN
Hardeep Nijjar's poster outside a gurdwara in Surrey, British Columbia, Sept. 18

AP

The event would have passed unexamined had it not been for a meeting between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Trudeau, just a few hours before it kicked off. As it turns out, the G20 had not been all about hugs and millet delicacies—behind the scenes, some hard talk had flowed. Meeting on the sidelines, Modi had conveyed "strong concerns" about continuing "anti-India activities by extremist elements" on Canadian soil. Trudeau justified such events, linking them with the country's democratic freedoms, while assuring Modi no hate crimes would be allowed. There are few takers for such assurances in New Delhi. "We have been pushing for action, but only get assurances," says a top Indian diplomat, not wishing to be named.

CRITICS SAY TRUDEAU HAS KEPT CANADA'S INTERESTS AT STAKE TO PLEASE PRO-KHALISTANI ELEMENTS

Even before he landed in New Delhi, Trudeau had miffed the Modi regime when he told scribes in Singapore that he would be taking up the issue of "foreign interference" in Canadian affairs with India. Many in Canada believe Trudeau, who has drawn much flak for a "disastrous" tour of India in 2018 and not doing enough to "confront" Modi, has now chosen the path of escalating tensions to ease pressure back home. He's also reaching out to other countries in the 'Five Eyes' intelligence alliance, including the US, UK and Australia, to build a little club of India-baiters.

How does playing hardball on this issue benefit Trudeau? Pro-Khalistanis are a fringe among the Punjabi diaspora but have started dominating the religious as well as political discourse in Canada—with influence in 33 of the 338 electoral districts—after taking control of key gurdwaras in the country. In the 2021 federal election, Trudeau failed to secure a majority and his survival depends on the support of 25 MPs from Jagmeet Dhaliwal's New Democratic Party. Dhaliwal is an open supporter of the Khalistan movement, says Sameer Kaushal, a Vancouver-based radio presenter. In early May, Trudeau even attended a 'nagar kirtan' (Sikh religious procession) in Toronto that was flooded by Khalistan flags. Terry Milewski, a Canadian journalist, claims events like the referendum are leading to hate crimes, defacement of Hindu temples and bullying of other members of the diaspora who don't support the Khalistan cause. "Trudeau claims the action of a few doesn't reflect the conduct of the whole community," adds Kaushal. "He must show what action he has taken against those few."

India is also worried about Canada becoming a safe haven for gangsters